

Bridge: A Trick-Taking Game

Two partnerships, 52 cards, thirteen tricks to win: the side that bids highest in the auction chooses how the hand is played.



1 The deck and the partnerships

♠ J8 ♥ AQJ43 ♦ KQ3 ♣ A98

one hand: 13 cards

Bridge is a partnership game: the player across the table is your partner, so it's **North-South against East-West**. The deck has **52 cards** in four suits of 13, from the ace down to the two.

♠ Spades ♥ Hearts ♦ Diamonds ♣ Clubs

Honors: A K Q J 10. Spot cards: 9 down to 2.

No cards in a suit: a **void**. One card: a **singleton**. Two: a **doubleton**.

2 The trick

The first card played is the **opening lead**. The others, in clockwise order, must **follow suit**: play a card of the same suit.

The highest card of the suit led wins the trick.



West leads the K♠, North plays the 3, East the 7: South wins with the **ace**. A player out of the suit **discards** another card, and a discard never wins the trick.

3 Dummy and declarer

After the opening lead, **dummy** lays its cards face up on the table, sorted by suit, and takes no further part: its partner, **declarer**, chooses every card.

Declarer sees 26 cards: their own 13 and dummy's 13. That makes it possible to plan the play.

The defenders see only their own cards and dummy's, never their partner's.

4 Trumps or notrump

Trumps: one suit gets special power. A player out of the suit led can **ruff** with a trump and win the trick.

Ruffing: only when you can't follow suit, and never compulsory. If two players ruff, the higher trump wins.

Notrump (NT): no suit can ruff. A player out of a suit can only discard.

5 The auction and the contract

2♥

Through an auction a side commits to taking a number of tricks: the highest bid chooses how the hand is played. The number counts tricks **beyond the first six**: "2♥" means **at least 8 tricks, with hearts as trumps**.

From the top: **NT** > ♠ > ♥ > ♦ > ♣ after 1♥ you can bid 1♠; 1♦ and 1♣ need the 2 level

When a bid is followed by three passes, that bid becomes the contract.

6 Scoring

EACH TRICK BID BEYOND SIX

Clubs ♣ and diamonds ♦ 20

Hearts ♥ and spades ♠ 30

Notrump 40 the first, 30 the rest

Game: the tricks bid are worth at least 100.

3NT 4♥ 4♠ 5♣ 5♦

BONUSES AND PENALTIES

NON VUL · VUL

Game 300 · 500

Small slam (12 tricks) 500 · 750

Grand slam (13 tricks) 1000 · 1500

Each trick down 50 · 100

Winners and Establishable Cards

As soon as dummy comes down, declarer asks: how many tricks do I have? Where can I find more?



1 Winner

A card that, **played now**, wins the trick. Also called a **sure trick**.

A

K

3

2

♠

♠

♠

♠

2 winners

the ace and the king

2 Establishable card

A card that **will become** a winner after some work. Here the ace is missing: keep leading the suit until an opponent takes it.

K

Q

J

10

♠

♠

♠

♠

0 winners

3 establishable

3 Establishing by force

Lead the suit one card at a time until the opponents take their higher honors. **It is the only technique that always works**: one hundred percent of the time.

4 Equal cards

Touching cards have the same power: in **AKQJ** the jack wins just like the ace, 4 winners. It works **across both hands** too: with AQ2 in dummy, South's king is a winner.

N

♠

AQ2

3 winners

S

♠

K43

as long as two honors never fall on the same trick

5 The long side rules

Never more tricks than cards in the long hand.

N

♠

J109

S

♠

AKQ

3 on each side

3 tricks

N

♥

109

S

♥

AKQJ2

South has 5

5 tricks

N

♦

AKJ942

S

♦

Q103

North has 6

6 tricks

6 How many can you establish?

Cards in the long hand, minus the missing honors.

N

♣

KQ92

S

♣

J103

A missing

4 - 1 = 3

N

♣

KQ954

S

♣

J103

A missing

5 - 1 = 4

N

♥

Q9854

S

♥

J1032

A K missing

5 - 2 = 3

N

♠

KJ9863

S

♠

Q102

A missing

6 - 1 = 5

7 Declarer's plan, after the opening lead

1 · Count your winners

Suit by suit, across both hands.

2 · Find what to establish

Start with the suit that can give **the most tricks**.

3 · Establish, then cash

Don't rush to play your winners: you need them later.

Careful: sometimes, once the suit is established, you must regain the lead before you can cash it.

8 Let's try: South declares, West leads

NORTH · DUMMY

♠ AQ8

♥ 76

♦ K65

♣ K10932

SOUTH · DECLARER

♠ K62

♥ A982

♦ A43

♣ QJ6

West leads the Q♦

SUIT	WINNERS	ESTABLISHABLE	
♠ Spades	3	—	A K Q
♥ Hearts	1	—	A
♦ Diamonds	2	—	A K
♣ Clubs	0	4	5 - 1: the ace is missing
Total	6	+ 4	= 10 tricks

South wins the lead → plays **clubs** at once until the ace is gone → wins any return and cashes out

The Defenders' Perspective

The defense has a plan too: it starts with the opening lead and goes on by reading the cards as they fall.

1 The goal

Defeat the contract

If North-South need 9 tricks, East-West need only 5.

The opening lead is an edge

The player on declarer's left makes it: it is the first move of the defensive plan.

No hurry

Like declarer, the defense does not cash its winners at once: they are needed to establish tricks.

2 Which suit to lead

Your longest suit. With two of equal length, the one with better honors.

♠ J104 ♥ QJ103
♦ J762 ♣ K2

Four hearts and four diamonds:
hearts, better honors → ♥

♠ Q9732 ♥ KQ
♦ AJ62 ♣ 92

The long suit is spades
→ 2♠

♠ A4 ♥ 94
♦ A762 ♣ KQJ92

Clubs, no doubt → ♣.
Cashing the aces gives tricks away.

3 Which card to lead

Honors: A K Q J 10

Spot cards: 9 down to 2

1 · Top of a sequence

Three high cards in a row, or nearly: KQJ, QJ10, KQ10, AQJ. Lead the highest of the touching cards.

KQJ103 K · denies A, shows Q
K10543 3 · holds an honor

2 · Low from an honor

At least the jack but no sequence: lead your lowest card.

QJ93 Q · denies K, shows J
AJ952 2 · holds an honor

3 · Second highest

No sequence and nothing above the 10: lead the second card from the top.

J1094 J · denies Q, shows 10
108654 8 · no honor

4 Third hand

N ♥ 82
W ♥ KJ754 E ♥ Q96
S ♥ A103

Try to win. West leads the 4: East plays the queen. With a low card, South wins the 10 and takes two tricks.

N ♠ 872
W ♠ KQ1053 E ♠ A4
S ♠ J96

Don't block. West leads the king: East overtakes with the ace and returns the suit. West cashes five tricks.

Return partner's suit whenever you can, unless dummy and your own cards say to switch.

5 Third hand: lowest

With equal cards, third hand plays the lowest. The player who leads plays the highest.

WITH	LEADING	THIRD
K Q J	K	J
A K Q	A	Q
J 10 9	J	9

N ♦ 754
W ♦ 2 E ♦ KQ106
S ♦ ?
2 led → ♥

N ♣ 543
W ♣ 6 E ♣ AK2
S ♣ ?
6 led → ♠

6 The leader's inference

The card third hand plays to win the trick denies the card just below it.

You lead the 3, East plays the **jack**, South wins with the **queen**.

N ♠ 842
W ♠ K9653 E ♠ J?
S ♠ Q?
what you see

N ♠ 842
W ♠ K9653 E ♠ J7
S ♠ AQ10
what you infer

With J10 East would have played the 10, with the ace East would have played it: **South has the 10 and the ace**. Don't lead the suit again; wait for partner to lead it.

Establishing Long and Positional Cards

Beyond force: tricks from the length of a suit and from where the opponents' honors sit.



1 Three ways to establish

By force Equal cards: give up the higher honor. Seen already.

By length Play the suit until the opponents have none left.

By position Your honor wins if the opponents' honor is in the right place.

2 By length

When your side holds **more cards than the opponents** (7 is enough), the last ones become winners even if low. What counts: the **length** of the long hand and how the rest **split**.

Diagram showing a club suit: North has 762, West has 1085, East has J9, and South has AKQ43. A K Q, then the 4 and 3 are good: **5 tricks**.

Diagram showing a diamond suit: North has 109762, West has AQ, East has 8543, and South has 8543. Two rounds: the honor. North has **3 tricks** established.

Long suits always produce tricks, even "ugly" ones.

3 Keep your entries

Established cards must be reachable. West leads the 10♥: to take 13 tricks South wins **with the ace or king**, not the jack.

Diagram showing a heart suit: North has 963, West has J7, East has Q1054, and South has AK82. West has 109865, East has 732, and South has AKJ. West has 1084, East has QJ93, and South has AK76. West has J53, East has 108, and South has KQ.

1. K♥, then K♣ and Q♣.
2. J♥ to the Q♥: you're in dummy.
3. A♣ and the established clubs: a 3-2 split, 13 tricks.

4 By position: where their honor sits

Diagram showing a heart suit: North has AQ5, West has ?, East has ?, and South has 863. **Finesse**: low toward the queen. Works if West has the king.

Diagram showing a heart suit: North has K85, West has ?, East has ?, and South has 763. Low toward the lone king. Works if West has the ace.

Diagram showing a spade suit: North has A63, West has ?, East has ?, and South has QJ10. Lead the queen: if West covers, J and 10 are promoted. Works if West has the king.

If their honor is in the wrong place nothing helps: but the try works about half the time.

5 Honor or low card?

Ask yourself whether you'd be glad to see your honor covered. If you gain nothing, don't lead it first.

Diagram showing a club suit: North has A543, West has Q72, and South has Q72. Leading the queen establishes nothing: the opponents hold the J, 10 and 9. Play **low toward the queen**, hoping East has the king.

6 On defense: cover an honor with an honor

Second hand: low on low, honor on honor.

Diagram showing a diamond suit: North has AQ94, West has K83, East has 1072, and South has J65. If South leads the J, West covers with the K: East's 10 becomes a winner. If South leads the 5, West plays low.

7 The stopper

Diagram showing a spade suit: North has 87, West has 9432, East has QJ, and South has AK1065.

Cards that stop the opponents from taking every trick in a suit. East's queen and jack fall, but **West's 9 wins the fourth round**: one careless discard and the stopper is gone.

On defense: if dummy has a long suit and partner holds fewer cards in it than you, don't discard a single one.

The No Trump Play Plan

Your winners are rarely enough: the plan tells you how many tricks are missing, where to find them and how to cash them.



1 Four questions after the opening lead

- 1 How many sure tricks do I have?
- 2 How many more does the contract need?
- 3 Which suits can provide them?
- 4 How do I get them?

2 Entries and communication

Entry: the card that wins the trick in the right hand at the right time.

Link: the card that, thanks to the entry, carries the lead from one hand to the other.

NORTH ♠ 872 ♥ A7 ♦ J10952 ♣ J32
SOUTH ♠ AK3 ♥ K85 ♦ KQ3 ♣ A854
3NT · West leads the 2♥

Winners: 2 spades, 2 hearts, 1 club. Diamonds give 4 more after losing to the ace.

1. Win with the **king of hearts**: the ace stays with the diamonds.
2. Lead **South's diamond honors** first, from the short side.

Protect the entries next to the long suit you want to establish.

3 Count the opponents' tricks too

NORTH ♠ 653 ♥ 32 ♦ AQJ109 ♣ 764
SOUTH ♠ AKQ ♥ A4 ♦ 872 ♣ KQJ105
3NT · West leads the K♥

5 winners, 4 more needed. Clubs would provide them, but only **by losing to the ace**: after the lead the defenders have at least 4 hearts to cash, and with the A♣ that makes 5. Take the **diamond finesse** instead: it doesn't give up the lead.

4 Win in the right hand

NORTH ♠ 763 ♥ 864 ♦ A653 ♣ QJ3
SOUTH ♠ AKQ ♥ A32 ♦ K8 ♣ A10985
3NT · West leads the 2♦

Before winning the lead, decide your next move. Clubs must be led **from North toward South**, to catch the king with East: so win with **dummy's ace of diamonds** and lead the queen of clubs.

5 The duck

N ♣ A72
S ♣ K8653

South has few entries. If declarer plays A, K and another club, the two good clubs have no entry. Better to **duck at once**: the 2 to the 3. Then the A, a club to the K and all the rest.

Give up early a trick you'd lose anyway, to keep communication in the suit.

6 Blocked suits

N ♠ KQ72
S ♠ AJ83
flows

N ♠ QJ109
S ♠ AK
blocked

N ♥ KQ2
S ♥ AJ43
K, Q, then
2 to the A

N ♦ K2
S ♦ AQJ43
K, then
a low card

To avoid blocking: honors from the short side first.

7 Unblocking a suit

NORTH ♠ 6542 ♥ 103 ♦ KQJ102 ♣ 54
SOUTH ♠ A73 ♥ AKQJ2 ♦ A ♣ AK32
West leads the K♠

13 winners, but the singleton ace blocks the diamonds. There is an entry: dummy's **10 of hearts**. South cashes the A♦, plays the 2♥ to the 10♥ and runs the K Q J 10 of diamonds.

Blocked suit? Use the other suits to get around the block.

Playing with Trumps

One suit gets special power: a player out of the suit led can win the trick with a trump.



1 Trumps, ruffs and fits

To ruff: to win a trick with a trump when you have no cards left in the suit led.

Fit: your side holds at least 8 cards in a suit. A trump contract pays when your side holds more trumps than the opponents.

Even a weak suit pays as trumps: with ♥ QJ10987 you take at least 4 tricks.

In the trump suit, cards sure to be established count as winners.

2 Drawing trumps

NORTH	
♠	874
♥	109
♦	KQJ2
♣	AK63
WEST	
♠	AKQ92
♥	432
♦	63
♣	1052
EAST	
♠	J1065
♥	86
♦	10987
♣	QJ4
SOUTH	
♠	3
♥	AKQJ75
♦	A54
♣	987

4♥ · West leads the A♠ and K♠

South ruffs the K♠. Cashing the diamonds at once, West would ruff the third round. First **three rounds of hearts** to draw the defenders' trumps, then the diamonds safely: **12 tricks**, 6 hearts, 4 diamonds, 2 clubs. In notrump South would have lost the first five.

Side-suit winners are only relative: cash them safely only after drawing trumps.

Control: by ruffing, South stopped West's spades. No trick was gained: 5 hearts cashed plus 1 ruff still make 6.

3 Ruffing in the short hand

NORTH	
♠	1095
♥	4
♦	A762
♣	A10842
WEST	
♠	2
♥	KJ87
♦	J1054
♣	KQJ7
EAST	
♠	864
♥	Q10952
♦	Q83
♣	93
SOUTH	
♠	AKQJ73
♥	A63
♦	K9
♣	65

4♠ · West leads the K♣

Winners: 6 spades, 1 heart, 2 diamonds, 1 club. But spades can produce **8 tricks** instead of 6, ruffing with dummy's trumps:

1. A♣, A♥ and a heart ruffed in dummy.
2. A spade to a high honor in hand, then a heart ruffed in dummy.
3. Back to hand with the K♦, draw trumps, A♦: **12 tricks**.

Don't always draw trumps at once: first take the ruffs in the short hand, the one with fewer trumps.

A ruff gains only if it adds at least one trick to what the suit would give anyway.

4 Establishing with ruffs

NORTH	♠ KJ4	♥ A7	♦ 65	♣ A98753
SOUTH	♠ AQ8652	♥ 986	♦ A3	♣ K2

4♠ · West leads the K♦

In a trump contract you can establish a long suit **without losing the lead**: the low cards you would have to lose get ruffed instead.

1. A♦, two rounds of trumps.
2. K♣, A♣ and a club ruffed in hand: if the opponents' clubs split 3-2, they all fall.
3. Dummy's three clubs are good, with the **ace of hearts** as the entry: **13 tricks**.

The Play Plan with Trumps

The opponents can ruff too. The plan decides when to draw trumps, when to wait, what comes first.



1 On defense: leading against a trump contract

Quick tricks

A long suit helps little: declarer will ruff it. **Two touching honors** are enough to lead from a sequence.

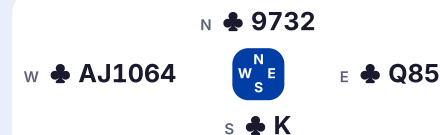
♠ KQ7 ♥ 62 ♦ J9732 ♣ A72
against 4♥: the K♠, better than the 2♦.

Looking for a ruff

Lead a short suit to get a ruff. From two cards, **always the higher**: from 74 the 7, from 102 the 10, from A9 the ace.

♠ 2 ♥ A62 ♦ J982 ♣ Q8752
against 4♥: the 2♠.

Never underlead an ace



Against 4♥ the J♣ lets South's singleton king win, and the ace never scores.

2 Declarer: draw trumps?

With long side-suit winners or establishable cards, draw trumps: otherwise they'll get ruffed.

N ♥ K54
S ♥ A2
5 cards: a ruff is very unlikely

N ♥ K732
S ♥ A4
6 cards: still a low risk

N ♥ KQJ3
S ♥ A42
7 cards: the third round survives under 50%

N ♥ 732
S ♥ KQJ104
after losing the ace: maybe one trick, not two

Spades are trumps, hearts are the side suit: the more cards your side holds, the likelier an honor gets ruffed.

3 Only short winners? Ruff

NORTH ♠ AK8 ♥ A743 ♦ 732 ♣ J92
SOUTH ♠ 6532 ♥ 8 ♦ AK854 ♣ 853
2♦ · West leads the Q♥

You need 8 tricks; the side suits give 3. Drawing trumps, diamonds take 4, never 5. So: A♥, heart ruffed with the 4; spade to the ace, heart ruffed with the 5; spade to the king, heart ruffed with the 8. Hearts 4-4: **8 tricks**.

4 Wait to draw trumps

NORTH ♠ 82 ♥ 83 ♦ A92 ♣ Q97543
SOUTH ♠ AKQJ95 ♥ A92 ♦ 873 ♣ A
4♠ · West leads the 2♣

9 tricks, and drawing trumps leaves 9. At once **A♥ and a heart**; later a heart ruffed in dummy: **10 tricks**. Even one round of trumps would be fatal: on lead with a heart, a defender plays a trump and the ruff is gone.

Wait to draw trumps if you need ruffs in the short hand.

5 Setting up a ruff

N ♠ xxx ♥ 32
S ♠ AKQ32 ♥ A74

A♥ and a heart, then a heart ruffed in dummy.

N ♠ xxxx ♥ 85
S ♠ AKQ64 ♥ 932

Duck a heart twice: then ruff the third.

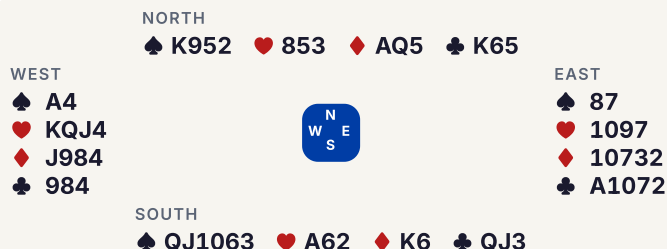
N ♠ xxx ♥ K6
S ♠ AKQ32 ♥ Q52

K♥, lose to the ace, cash the queen and ruff.

N ♠ xx ♥ K7
S ♠ AKQ743 ♥ A53

K♥, A♥, then a heart ruff.

6 Urgent things first



4♠, West leads the K♥. Win and draw trumps, and the defense takes two hearts, the A♠ and the A♣: down one. Instead, after the A♥, South cashes K♦, Q♦, A♦ discarding a heart: the third heart can now be ruffed.

When your plan gives up the lead, always ask what the opponents will do next.

Hand Evaluation

Strength decides whether to open and at what level; shape decides which suit.



1 High card points

4 Ace	3 King	2 Queen	1 Jack
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Milton Work's count: **10 points** in each suit, **40** in the deck.

♠ AQ854 ♥ K9 ♦ J87 ♣ AKJ **18 HCP**

2 The partnership's points

The more points a side holds, the more tricks it takes. As a guide:

20-24 part score	25-31 game	32-36 small slam	37+ grand slam
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Cards from the 10 down don't count: here 3 + 1 + 4 + 2 + 3 + 2 = **15 HCP**.

♠ KJ73 ♥ AQ5 ♦ K84 ♣ Q92 **15 HCP**

3 When to open

The opening bid is the first call other than pass: it's a choice, not a duty, and it depends on strength.

13+ always open	12 almost always open	11 sometimes, with concentrated honors	0-10 pass
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♠ 93 ♥ J7 ♦ KQJ75 ♣ K753 10 HCP: nice diamonds, but not enough strength **Pass**

4 Balanced or unbalanced

There are three **balanced** shapes:

	HAND	POINTS	OPENING
4-3-3-3	balanced	15-17	1NT
4-4-3-2	balanced	12-14 or 18-20	1 of a suit
5-3-3-2	unbalanced	12-20	1 of a suit

5 Which suit to open

1♥ and 1♠ need at least five cards; 1♦ at least four; otherwise 1♣, even with two.

With one long suit, open it; with two suits of five or more, open the higher-ranking.

♠ K2 ♥ 4 ♦ KJ876 ♣ AQ873	two five-card suits: the higher	1♦
♠ AQJ3 ♥ KJ62 ♦ Q7 ♣ 853	no five-card major, only two diamonds	1♣
♠ 53 ♥ AJ4 ♦ K9 ♣ AJ10762	long suit	1♣

6 Strong openings

2♦, 2♥, 2♠: an unbalanced hand with 21+ HCP, or with about 8-9 winners. Open your long suit.

2NT: balanced, 21-23. 2♣: balanced with 24+, or a strong club-based hand.

Responder may not pass a two-level suit opening.

7 Preemptive openings

At the 3 and 4 levels: a suit of **at least 7 cards** with at least two honors, and nothing outside. The message: "on my own I take 3 tricks fewer than I bid."

♠ AKQ9653 ♥ 2 ♦ 65 ♣ 873	7 winners	4♠
♠ — ♥ 843 ♦ KQJ8763 ♣ 972	6 winners	3♦

Opening and Response

1NT and 2NT describe the hand almost completely: responder adds up the points and picks the contract.

1 The 1NT opening

15, 16 or 17 HCP and a balanced hand (4-3-3-3, 4-4-3-2, 5-3-3-2): open 1NT, which takes priority over a suit opening.

It promises at least two cards in every suit.

♠ KQ76 ♥ AQ62 ♦ KQ7 ♣ 98 16 HCP, 4-4-3-2

1NT

♠ J6 ♥ KQ7 ♦ KJ2 ♣ AJ854 15 HCP, 5-3-3-2

1NT

2 Responder is the captain

Responder knows opener holds 15-17, adds their own points and chooses the level. Responses are sign-offs, invitations or forcing bids.

Sign-offs · opener passes

2♥ 2♠ weak hand (0-7) with 5+ cards: part score

3NT game values, no fit

4♥ 4♠ a sure fit and game values

Invitations · opener decides

2NT with 8 HCP: opener passes with 15, bids 3NT with 16-17

3♥ 3♠ "raise with a maximum, otherwise pass"

over 1NT ♠ AQ8743 ♥ K5 ♦ J42 ♣ 76 10 HCP, 6 spades: fit and game

4♠

over 1NT ♠ 876 ♥ J109652 ♦ 42 ♣ 76 1 HCP, 6 hearts: 2♥ beats 1NT

2♥

3 Stayman: 2♣

With **at least 8 HCP** and a four- or five-card major, responder asks: "do you have four hearts or four spades?"

2♦

neither 4 hearts nor 4 spades

2♥

4 hearts, fewer than 4 spades

2♠

4 spades, fewer than 4 hearts

2NT

4 hearts and 4 spades

♠ KJ76 ♥ A842 ♦ 65 ♣ K83

1NT - 2♣ - 2♥ - 4♥ 4-4 fit found, game values.

opener ♠ AK86 ♥ Q93 ♦ KJ7 ♣ A84 Over 2♣ opener bids 2♠: four spades and fewer than four hearts.

4-4 fit found: game, or slam.

No fit: play in notrump, at the level the points allow.

A 5-3 fit still possible: responder bids the five-card suit.

4 The 2NT opening

21, 22 or 23 HCP and a balanced hand: no singletons, no voids, no six-card suits.

Pass part-score hand

3♥ 3♠ 5+ card suit, game values: opener raises with a fit, otherwise bids 3NT

3♣ Stayman: 3♦ no four-card major, 3♥ four hearts, 3♠ four spades, 3NT both

3NT game with no four-card major: to play

♠ 95 ♥ J965 ♦ 865 ♣ AJ92

2NT - 3♣ - 3♥ - 4♥

over 2NT ♠ 43 ♥ K52 ♦ AJ952 ♣ 976

3NT

8 HCP, no four-card major: the side holds 29-31, so play 3NT. This direct 3NT denies a four-card major; opener's 3NT after 3♣ shows both.

Opening bids of 1 in a suit. The responses

Responder looks for a fit and measures strength: each response tells opener to stop or go on.



1 Three kinds of response

Limit bids

They show a minimum and a maximum: opener may pass.

Invitational

They show a limit but ask opener for something extra.

Forcing

A new suit: opener may not pass.

With 5 or more points never pass: opener may hold up to 20, and 25 between you means game.

2 Raises

RESPONSE	POINTS	MEANING
1♦ – 2♦	5-9	limit: with a minimum opener, no game
1♥ – 3♥	10-11	invitational: game if opener has 14+
1♠ – 4♠	max 11	4+ card fit and a hand made for ruffing

Over 1♥/1♠ three-card support is enough; over 1♦ you need four. Raises are not forcing.

PARTNER OPENS 1♦

♠ Q53 ♥ A5 ♦ Q874 ♣ 7654
→ 2♦: 7 points and four diamonds.

3 Revaluing with a fit

With a 4+ card fit and an unbalanced hand, responder adds to the HCP: number of trumps minus cards in the shortest suit.

PARTNER OPENS 1♥

♠ 8 ♥ KJ72 ♦ KQ74 ♣ 7642
9 HCP + (4 – 1) = 12 → 4♥.

Not with 4-3-3-3: without a short suit there is nothing to ruff.

4 New suits: forcing

RESPONSE	POINTS	MEANING
1♣ – 1♥	5+	one-over-one: 4+ cards, no upper limit; opener must bid again
1♠ – 2♦	12+	two-over-one: forcing to game

Opening 1♥ or 1♠ shows five; as a response, four are enough.

PARTNER OPENS 1♣

♠ 82 ♥ KJ72 ♦ Q92 ♣ 7642
→ 1♥: shows four hearts. Partner raises, bids 1♠ or rebids.

- Two five-card suits: the higher-ranking first.
- A five-card and a four-card suit: the five-card suit first.
- Two four-card suits: the cheaper first.

Don't jump if you can bid your suit at the 1 level: 1♥ shows 5 or more points, even 17.

5 Notrump responses

RESPONSE	POINTS	MEANING
1NT	5-10	not forcing; denies a 4-card suit biddable at the 1 level
2NT	11	invitational; denies a major-suit fit
3NT	12-15	game: balanced, no playable major

PARTNER OPENS 1♥

♠ 32 ♥ 4 ♦ QJ973 ♣ KQ852
Two five-card suits, only 8 points: too weak for the 2 level → 1NT.

6 Before you respond: a checklist

1 · Do I have a fit?

Show it now, at the level my points allow.

2 · If not, a new suit?

Bid it: it is forcing and has no upper limit.

3 · Neither?

Respond in notrump, according to my points.

The opener describes

With the second bid opener tells how strong the hand is and how it is shaped: partner needs two bids to know.

1 Decide or describe?

Non-forcing response

Opener **decides**: pass, invite or bid game.

One-over-one response

Opener describes **strength and shape**.

Two-over-one response

Opener describes **shape only**: game is already assured.

2 Minimum and strong hands

Minimum · 12-15

Describe the hand without passing the safety level.

Strong · 16-20

Go past the safety level to show the extra strength.

Safety level: the last contract beyond which, with no fit and only 18-19 points between you, a reasonable result is no longer sure.

3 Minimum hand after a one-over-one

Balanced

Safety level = **1NT**

1♥ – 1♠ – ?

♠ J7 ♥ KQ943 ♦ AQ65 ♣ J7

Unbalanced, safety level 2♥: diamonds fit below it → **2♦**.

Unbalanced

Safety level = **2 of the opening suit**

1♣ – 1♠ – ?

♠ AK7 ♥ QJ43 ♦ 42 ♣ KJ86

Balanced, safety level 1NT: hearts would go past it → **1NT**.

4 Strong hand: go past the safety level

After a one-over-one response, with a strong hand opener always describes it by going past the safety level.

1♣ – 1♦ – ?

♠ AKJ7 ♥ Q43 ♦ 4 ♣ AKJ86

Spades with a jump → **2♠**: at least 16 points, four spades and long clubs.

1♥ – 1♠ – ?

♠ A7 ♥ AQ943 ♦ 4 ♣ AKJ86

Within the safety level it would be 2♣; the jump → **3♣** shows the strength.

1♦ – 1♠ – ?

♠ A987 ♥ AK3 ♦ KQ874 ♣ 6

16 points and four spades: raise to the 3 level → **3♠**.

BALANCED 18-20

Too much for 1NT, too little to open 2NT: jump to **2NT** (1♥ – 1♠ – 2NT).

5 After a two-over-one

The response is forcing to game: opener describes, whether minimum or strong.

WEST 1♦ – EAST 2♣ – WEST ?

♠ 93 ♥ AK73 ♦ KQJ5 ♣ 983

Nothing extra, but opener describes → **2♥**. East, no longer worried about that suit, bids 3NT.

6 Then responder

After a one-over-one, once opener has bid twice:

1NT, old suit at minimum level	not forcing
2NT, old suit with a jump	invitational
new suit	forcing

A new suit is the only way to make opener bid again: it acts as a prod and needs no length.

The Overcall

How to enter the opponents' auction: three ways, each with its own requirements.

1 Three ways to compete

An overcall is the first call other than Pass by the side opposite the opener. It is a **free choice**: you come in only when it pays.

Double

Short in the opponent's suit, the other three suits playable. 12–16 points.

1NT

Like a 1NT opening: 15–17 balanced, with a **stopper** in opener's suit.

Suit overcall

A very good suit, or plenty of points that fit neither the double nor 1NT. 16/17 at most.

2 The takeout double

The double asks partner to choose a suit and bid it at the level partner thinks you can play.

over 1♣ or 1♦

both majors: 4-4 or 4-3, never 4-2

over 1♥

promises 4 spades

over 1♠

promises 4 hearts

South opens 1♦, West to bid

♠ KJ98 ♥ AQ74 ♦ 5 ♣ K983

Double: both four-card majors, a singleton diamond and the right strength.

South opens 1♣, your call

♠ 9854 ♥ K4 ♦ A765 ♣ AJ3

Pass: the points are there, but hearts are missing. Partner would feel betrayed.

3 The doubler's partner

Advancer must pick a suit: the minimum for bidding at the cheapest level is zero points.

1♦ – Double – Pass – ?

♠ 54 ♥ J986 ♦ 952 ♣ Q532

1♥: never pass. 1♦ doubled would be a disaster.

1♦ – Double – Pass – ?

♠ KJ954 ♥ A76 ♦ 95 ♣ K64

4♠: bid as if you could see partner's cards, at least 4-3 in the majors.

1♦ – Double – Pass – ?

♠ K42 ♥ Q86 ♦ AJ10 ♣ K954

3NT: enough points, no major fit, a diamond stopper.

4 The 1NT overcall

Same strength and shape as a 1NT opening. The opponents already have a suit to lead, so you **need a stopper** in opener's suit.

South opens 1♥, West to bid

♠ AJ5 ♥ KJ7 ♦ AJ1053 ♣ K8

1NT: 17 points, balanced, a heart stopper.

5 The suit overcall

At the one level: 8–16 points, 5 cards with at least one honor (rarely 4 with two honors), or any 6 cards.

South opens 1♦

♠ 82 ♥ AKJ1042 ♦ 86 ♣ 983

1♥: 8 points, all of them in the suit.

6 Suit overcall, two level

10–16 points, usually **6 cards** with at least one honor. Exception: over 1♠, five hearts are enough, with an honor and 13+ points.

South opens 1♠

♠ 54 ♥ 98 ♦ KQJ862 ♣ A76

2♦: six cards with honors, 10 points.

Above 16/17 points don't overcall: double first, then bid your suit.

7 The overcaller's partner

Advancer starts from the **guaranteed minimum**. With **9+ points** never pass: $16 + 9 = 25$, game is possible. You may raise with only three cards.

Before you bid a suit, remember partner will lead it. If that makes your hair stand on end, the overcall is wrong.

In competitive auctions, 70% of the time opener's side buys the contract: every overcall guides the defense.

Developments after the opponent's intervention

How to go on when an opponent comes in: whoever bids now does so freely.

1 Forced and free bids

Without interference, responder must keep the bidding open even with 5 points: opener might hold 20. After an overcall opener gets another chance anyway, so any bid is a **free bid**.

A free bid always shows a hand that is happy to bid: more than the minimum.

a

With 4–5 points and nothing special, **pass**.

b

Notrump is no longer a forced response: it promises a **stopper** in their suit.

c

Every new suit shows **at least five cards**.

d

Two new calls: the **double** (over a suit) and the **redouble** (over a double).

1♦ – 1♠ – ?

♠ Jxx ♥ Kx ♦ Qxxx ♣ Qxxx

Pass: without the overcall you would bid 2♦. Now you don't have to: with 7 ordinary points, let partner decide.

2 After their double

The redouble (11+ points, any shape) is the only strong call. You describe the hand on the next round.

New suit not forcing: a proposed contract, at least 5–6 good cards, fewer than 11 points

Raises as without the double, but always with fewer than 11 points

1NT 7–10 points, happy to play it, with stoppers in the doubler's suits

1♥ – Double – ?

♠ Kx ♥ Jx ♦ AQx ♣ KQJ10xx

Redouble, not 2♣: after the double, 2♣ would show fewer than 11 points.

1♥ – Double – ?

♠ xx ♥ Jx ♦ xxx ♣ KQ10xxx

2♣: "I'd be happy to play 2♣." A good six-card suit, not enough to redouble.

3 After a suit overcall

A new suit is forcing, with five or more cards. The double shows 8+ points (unlimited) and seeks a 4-4 fit.

1♦ – 1♠ – ?

♠ xx ♥ AQxxx ♦ Qx ♣ KJxx

2♥: a five-card suit and enough points for the two level.

Double: "I'd like to play in one of the other suits." With the points to bid but not the length for a new suit, it asks opener to bid another suit, or notrump if possible.

Raises don't change: you don't need five cards to raise.

4 What opener does

With ordinary hands, balanced or not, opener passes; with four-card support, opener raises by strength.

Opener bids freely only with an unbalanced minimum hand holding an **excellent one-suiter** or a **two-suiter with at least 10 cards**; with 18–20 balanced and a stopper, opener bids notrump at the lowest level. A suit rebid freely is always a really good suit.

1♦ – 1♥ – 1♠ – 2♥ – ?

♠ Jx ♥ Kx ♦ AQxxx ♣ Qxxx

Pass: a minimum two-suiter, in points and in shape, is an ordinary hand.

1♣ – Pass – 1♥ – 1♠ – ?

♠ AQxx ♥ x ♦ Qx ♣ KQxxxx

Pass: an unbalanced minimum, but no outstanding suit and no fit.